Transit's Conflicting Priorities

Calgary's transit network does two jobs. Council has never been asked how to balance them.

Transit provides two different types of service. **Frequency** service runs often enough that people can turn up and go, and it is what drives ridership. **Coverage** service puts a stop within a walk of nearly everyone, whether or not many people use it. Both are legitimate. They pull against each other, because every hour of service goes to one or the other.

Today we judge both the same way, mostly on productivity. The balance between them is set indirectly, through where new communities are built, what gets rezoned, and how the transit budget is allocated. **No one decides it on purpose.** Using the City's own published schedules, I measured how that balance has moved.

18%
of weekly service hours run every 10 minutes or better in fall 2026, down from 25% in 2016

+10%
growth in the area within walking distance of any service, 2016 to 2026

–3%
change in the area with 10-minute midday service over the same decade

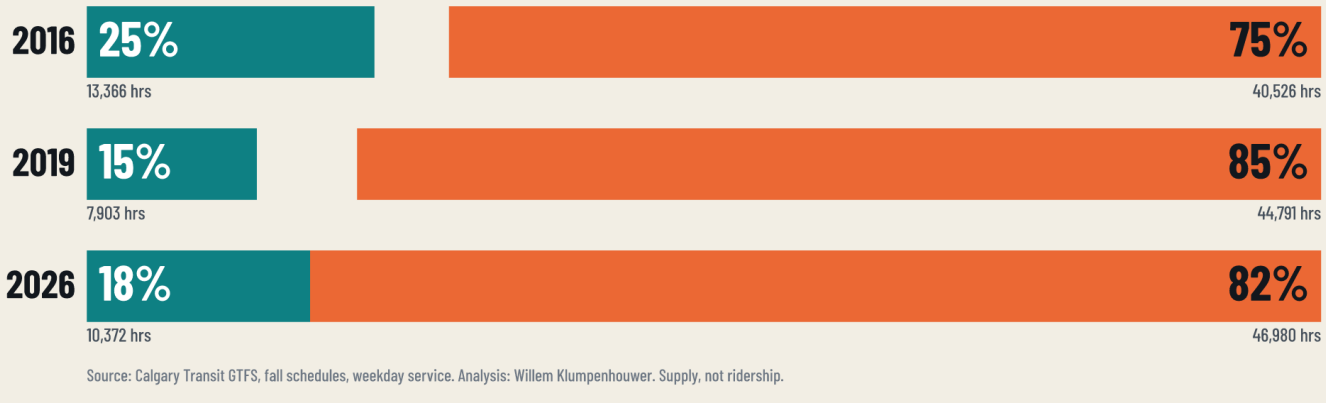
WHAT I'M ASKING COUNCIL TO DO

1. **Budget the two services separately.** In the 2027–2030 budget, show a coverage line and a frequency line, and have Council set the balance between them on purpose.
2. **Count the cost to both lines.** New community decisions and other major land use changes should report their effect on the coverage line and the frequency line before a decision is made.
3. **Ask Calgarians to help decide the balance.** Put the trade-off to the public directly.

This is a question about balance, not a call to cut coverage. Administration is best placed to cost the options.

The balance has drifted toward coverage

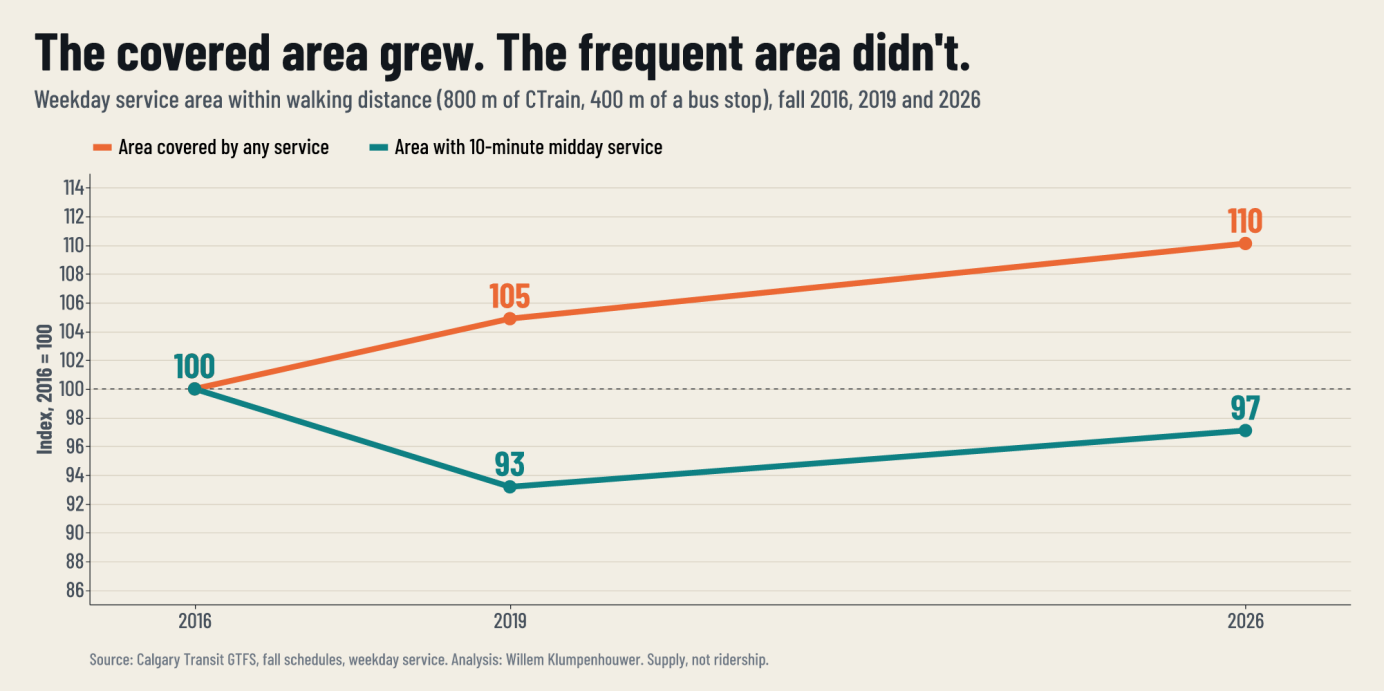
Every 10 min or better. Frequency hours -22%, coverage hours +16%, total +6%, 2016 to 2026



Source: Calgary Transit GTFS, fall schedules, weekday service. Analysis: Willem Klumpenhouwer. Supply, not ridership.

Share of weekly service hours running every 10 minutes or better (frequency) versus less often (coverage), fall schedules. Frequency hours fell 22%, coverage hours rose 16%, total hours rose 6%.

THE COVERAGE AREA GREW. THE FREQUENT AREA DID NOT.



Weekday area within walking distance of service (800 m of CTrain, 400 m of a bus stop). Most of the loss happened between 2016 and 2019, before the pandemic.

WHY THE BALANCE DRIFTS

New communities on the edge of the city each need coverage service to be reachable at all. Rezoning, and rezoning that does not happen, decides whether growth lands on corridors where frequent service works or on places where it does not. Transit budget decisions then split the hours. None of these decisions reports its effect on the balance.

Leaning toward coverage reaches more of the city but spreads hours thin, and ridership will likely shrink. Leaning toward frequency makes transit usable without a timetable, and ridership will likely grow, but some edge areas get less service and need a plan, such as on-demand service or a longer walk to a better stop.

WHAT THIS DOES AND DOES NOT SHOW

- **It measures supply, not ridership.** The City does not publish ridership by route. I am requesting it, and will share what I learn.
- **It is not an argument against coverage.** Coverage service is a real public good. The question is how much, chosen on purpose.
- **It does not rank routes.** I leave route-level choices and costing to Administration.
- The link between frequency and ridership follows Jarrett Walker's Transit Ridership Recipe. It is an established planning principle, not a result I measured here.

Method. Calgary Transit GTFS schedule feeds for the fall 2016, 2019 and 2026 signups, using one reference Tuesday, Friday, Saturday and Sunday in each, weighted to a week. Revenue hours run first stop to last stop, plus a 10% allowance for deadhead. A route-hour counts as frequent if trips per hour, per direction and smoothed over three hours, meet a 10-minute headway. CTrain hours are counted at 2.5 times bus hours (the result holds across 2 to 3 times). School specials are excluded. Walking distance uses 800 m around CTrain stops and 400 m around bus stops. Routes were restructured between 2016 and 2026, so I rely on area and stop-level measures for the trend. The 2026 schedule is the published fall plan, not observed service.

Data. City of Calgary Open Data. Code, data and an interactive explorer where you can change the frequency threshold: wklumpen.github.io/budget-2026. Analysis and design by Willem Klumpenhouwer.